If Pawar was constantly looking for ways to capture power in Delhi, another regional chieftain Naveen Patnaik seemed happy in his ‘den’ in Odisha. Naveenbabu is a fascinating politician whose life can be divided into two distinct halves. Before joining politics, he had enjoyed the high life—he had partied with Jackie Kennedy and Gore Vidal, he had written books on herbs and gardens, and his plush Aurangzeb Road residence was home to many wine-and-cheese evenings. And then in 1998, the Doon School-educated Naveen suddenly plunged into politics after the death of his father, the redoubtable Biju Patnaik. In 2000, he became Odisha chief minister from the Biju Janata Dal (BJD), carrying forward a family inheritance. He could barely speak Oriya at the time and had hardly lived in Bhubaneshwar. And yet, this denizen of metropolitan India, who loved his Scotch and his caviar, transformed himself into a tough local politician. The man who would once zip in and out of London made his first foreign trip as chief minister only in 2012.

So what was his secret formula that ensured repeated electoral success? ‘Among all the senior politicians in Odisha, he stands out as honest and earnest,’ claims a BJD MP. He could be gentle in private conversation, ruthless in his political dealings—he had split with the BJP just ahead of the 2009 elections and had removed close aides who he thought were conspiring against him. Most importantly, he had stayed the course. In the 2014 elections, he told me he wanted to remain equidistant from the BJP and the Congress. ‘We will not support anyone, neither Modi nor Rahul, after the elections,’ was his public position. He would be true to his word.

Perhaps his success offers hope to Rahul and the other elite children of dynastical privilege. The lesson is simple—even ‘disconnected’ Macaulay *putra*s can triumph in politics if they are ready to actually work at it with relentless focus. If only Rahul had made Lucknow his karmabhoomi like Naveen had Bhubaneshwar, who knows, the Congress leader might actually have emerged a battle-hardened politician.

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